

L4. SOCIO- POLITICAL PROFILE OF RULERS OF BENGAL

Muslim Rule



Turk- Afghan rule

- Central Asian rulers lost their home base, so they settled in India and carried out invasions in different parts of the of North Indian empires and other territories.
- Bengal was conquered and later occupied by Delhi but this was not a fixed position.
- The conflict between Central Asian rulers of Bengal and Delhi was an important factor behind syncretism or mixing at various levels.



Image: A former mosque in Pandua, where Ilyas Shah established the capital of Bengal. Choto Sona Mosque built during the reign of Alauddin Husain Shah



Turk Afghan Rule

- Turkh –Afgan rulers had a better relationship than the Ancient North Indian rulers. Allies on one the common anti-North Indian rule objective.
- Cultural and religious syncretism
- Mongol Kabbos, both Manosha and Chandi mongol



Manasa with Astika on her lap, 10th century Pala bronze from modern-day Bihar.



The Mughals

- Mughals introduced the great agricultural revolution which made Bengal wealthy
- Mughal rulers brought in many officials to supervise the new agriculture expansion and these officials often termed as "charismatics".
- Islam began to spread that later had many long term effects including the development of a new cultural identity.



Image: A riverside mosque in Mughal Dhaka



The Mughals

- The wealth of Bengal drew many foreigners
- After Aurangzeb the Mughal rule gradually began to decline
- The British traders made significant gain through the corrupt and powerless Mughal rulers



Image: Sir Thomas Roe's travel to Jahangir's court

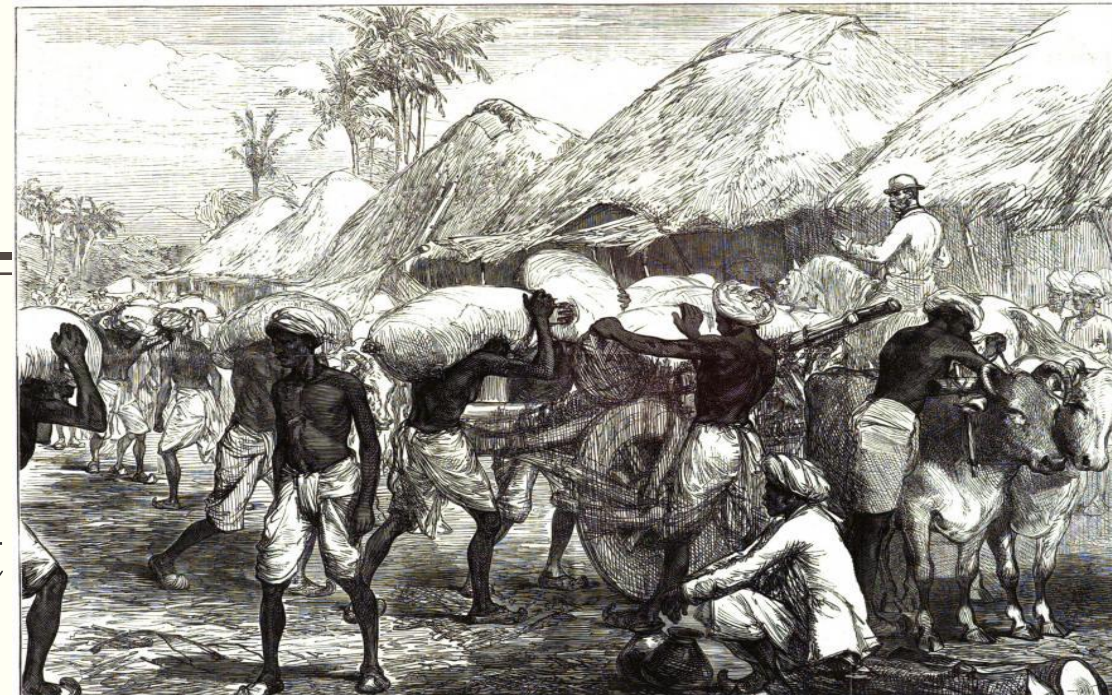
British rule

- British rule denotes a major transition from feudalism to capitalism
- Local rulers, indigenous merchant capitalist class supported the Brits as the common obstacle to capitalist growth was the crumbling feudal aristocracy
- The English East India Company was a trading outfit with great interest in profit

Image: Clive meeting with Mir Jafar after the Battle of Plassey, oil on canvas (Francis Hayman, c. 1762)



-
- The most important element was the establishment of the Permanent Settlement to introduce agro-capitalism and simultaneously create a loyalist
 - PS (1793) also generated peasant resistance





Profile of the rulers

- a. Bengal was ruled by foreigners whether from North India, central Asian or the West.
- b. The state system was weak and the dominantly peasant society was not part of any inter-state conflict politics till the British arrived
- c. North India was the center - Delhi, Karachi, Islamabad etc. London was the exception during British period but a very significant.
- d. The sense of the state emerged in colonial Bengal as the state for its own benefit entered the villages and peasants began to resist

